

Another big-ticket project linked to football and Bengal is the Bayern Munich-backed academy to be set up in Burdwan. It will be the first Bayern academy outside Germany whose launch announcement drew Bayern president and former German star, Rummenigge to Kolkata.

Academies are not new to India, so will Maradona matter? Will his visit—or Rummenigge's for that matter—really lift Indian football? Until the recent influx of soccer's heavyweights, the best known—and most often only—name that came to mind in connection with Indian football academies was the Tata Football Academy (TFA) set up in Jamshedpur by the Tata Steel Sports Foundation in 1987. Despite its best efforts—and the fact that it is still regarded as a premier training centre—the overall standing of Indian football has remained static.

Understanding the real impact of the Maradona visit lies in a dispassionate analysis of the timetables involved. For

starters, the Indian Football School cannot start functioning before 2012. Even the tender for the joint venture has not been floated, with Shamik Lahiri, MP and one of the key people behind Maradona's visit to Kolkata, saying that he has urged that it be done by January 31. For the moment, the project involves holding football clinics all over India to select 40 boys who will be trained at the school.

As far as the the Bayern project is concerned, no one is willing to state a fixed date as to when the academy will start functioning. The Burdwan District Sports Association entered into an agreement with Bayern and knowledge management group Techno India. Bayern's 24-acre academy is supposed to have a stadium and five football fields, four floodlit, two with artificial turfs. Kaushik Moulik, secretary of Bengal Centre, Munich, who was instrumental in getting Bayern Munich involved in this project says the process of scouting for players and coaches will begin in



PLAYERS PRACTISING AT THE
TATA FOOTBALL ACADEMY,
JAMSHEDPUR

SUVASHIS MULLICK